# *Chapter Twenty-Eight*

**John Softsword**

## *Between 1203 and 1213, John of England loses his Frankish lands and makes too many enemies*

THE LIONHEART WAS DEAD, and his brother John sat on the English throne.

The years since his coronation had not been good ones. As soon as John inherited the rule of England, Philip ceased to be his ally. Philip's intention had always been to reduce the power of the English crown; John, the thorn in Richard's side, was a welcome friend to the French king, but King John of England was his enemy.

John's older brother Geoffrey, dying before his father in 1186, had left only two daughters; but his wife Constance had given birth to a son named Arthur seven months later. As soon as Richard was dead, Philip insisted that Arthur, not John, was rightfully king of England. He welcomed Constance and the twelve-year-old Arthur to his court in Paris. The dukes of Anjou, Maine, and Tours—all English-held lands—joined him in rejecting John's claims.[1]

Three years of struggle followed. There were multiple battles, complicated negotiations, and at least two temporary truces. John used every weapon at his disposal, including marriage; he had divorced his first wife for failure to bear him an heir in 1199, and in 1200 he set his sights on the young daughter of the Count of Angoulême. Isabella of Angoulême—perhaps